

# FARO — User guide

## Book 2 of 3 · For whoever uses FARO

Prototype version: September 2026 · SHIFT 2026 Challenge · Gamification

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### How to read this book

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This guide describes FARO as it is built today: six tabs, two contextual screens and a Canvas integration that can run in two modes. Each chapter covers one screen: what it shows, what every control does, and **the exact rule that decides what you see**. When a rule has a number (a threshold, a score, a percentage), the number is the one in the code.

If you only have five minutes, read chapter 1 and chapter 5. They are the reason FARO exists.

### The two modes

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FARO can run on test data or on your real Canvas. The difference changes no screen; it changes where the data comes from.

| Mode             | What you see                                                                                                               | How to recognise it                                                 |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Simulated</b> | A sample course ( <i>Gestión de Proyectos</i> , 6 modules, 16 activities) with a student who has not logged in for 5 days. | In <b>Profile</b> → <b>Canvas</b> the badge says <i>Simulated</i> . |
| <b>Live</b>      | Your real Canvas course, your modules, your submissions.                                                                   | The badge says <i>Live</i> and your course name appears.            |

In *Live* mode FARO never talks to Canvas directly: it goes through its own server, which holds the credential. That is explained in Book 1 (Security) and set up by following Book 3 (Technical documentation).

### Contents

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1. What FARO is
2. First use: your destination
3. Home
4. Journey
5. Recovery

- 6. FARO Mentor
- 7. Community
- 8. Rewards and Progress
- 9. Profile
- 10. Rules FARO never breaks

**Hard to quit. Easy to return. No Game Over. Recalculate your route.**

# 1. What FARO is

FARO is a companion for people who study online while they work. It does not teach the course: Canvas does that. What FARO does is answer three questions Canvas does not.

- **What do I do now?** One single next step, sized to the time you actually have.
- **How do I come back?** When you have been away, a new route instead of a list of overdue work.
- **Am I alone in this?** Other people working on the same thing, without having to talk to anyone.

The product promise is short: **hard to quit, easy to return.**

## What it is NOT

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Worth saying, because it defines the rest of the guide:

- **It is not a video game.** It uses game mechanics, but there are no lives, no levels, no Game Over.
- **It is not a social network.** No followers, no ranking, no way to see who is ahead.
- **It does not replace Canvas.** Your grades, submissions and dates still live there. FARO only reads.
- **It is not a to-do list.** On no screen will you see "you have 14 overdue activities".

## Navigation

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Six tabs at the bottom (or on the left when the window is wide):

| Tab       | Answers                                      |
|-----------|----------------------------------------------|
| Home      | Where am I and what do I do now?             |
| Journey   | Where am I going?                            |
| FARO      | The mentor: explains, organises, accompanies |
| Community | Who is with me?                              |
| Rewards   | Your FARO points                             |
| Progress  | What you have built                          |

Two more screens are not tabs and appear when needed: **Recovery**, which opens from Home when you come back from an absence, and **Profile**, which opens from Community. They are kept out of the bar on purpose — FARO must not feel like yet another app with sections to manage.

## 2. First use: your destination

The first time you open FARO there are no tabs. Only three questions. Until you answer them there is nothing else — without a destination, FARO has nothing to plan with.

### Step 1 — Why are you studying?

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Eight options: career growth, better income, career change, a promotion, finish my degree, personal achievement, personal development, something else.

You pick one. It is not a personality test or a psychological formula: it is personalisation. There will be a week when you don't feel like opening the course, and this is what FARO will remind you of.

### Step 2 — What would finishing it let you do?

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A free text field. In your words, one line is enough. The example it shows: *"Lead my own projects instead of just executing them."*

That text later appears in Home, Journey and Progress as your destination. It is optional, but it is the part that makes the rest feel yours rather than a system's.

### Step 3 — How much time do you really have?

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Five options: **10, 20, 30, 45 or 60 minutes** a day.

**This is the step that changes FARO's behaviour the most.** It is not an aspiration, it is a budget:

- The Next Best Step is chosen among the activities that **fit** in that time.
- Recovery's feasibility check compares the minutes the course demands against the ones you declared.
- The recovery route is packed into days of that size.

If you put 60 because it sounds good and you only have 20, FARO will plan a week you cannot keep. Be honest before ambitious: that is why the screen says it in those words.

### Afterwards

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Your destination sits on a dark card with your goal and your sentence. Below it, the time chips stay editable: **you can change your available time whenever you want**, and everything else recalculates on its own.

To come back to this screen later: **Progress** → tap your destination card, at the bottom.

## 3. Home

Answers a single question: **where am I and what do I do now?** It is ordered top to bottom by what matters most.

### 1. Header

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A greeting by time of day, the course name, the progress bar and the percentage. Tapping it opens Journey.

Top right, in the app bar, is your **momentum** with its percentage. It is always visible, on every screen.

### 2. Attention strip (only when it applies)

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If FARO detected an interruption, a tappable strip appears:

- **Amber, "Welcome back"** — when you return after an absence. Opens Recovery.
- **White, with an attention message** — when your rhythm dropped but you did not leave. Opens the same.

If you are on track, nothing appears. FARO does not interrupt to congratulate you.

### 3. Next Best Step

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The dark card. **One single activity**, never a list. It shows the name, the estimated minutes, the minutes you said you have, and a line explaining why it is that one.

**How it is chosen** (the full rule, deliberately boring):

1. Take the open activities: the missed ones, the current one and the upcoming ones.
2. Of those, the ones that **fit in your available time**.
3. Of those, **the shortest**.
4. If none fits, the shortest of all, and the text tells you to start it and pause whenever you want.

The reason changes by case. If the step is overdue: *"This step reopens the route. Everything after it gets easier."*

**Start this step** marks it as completed and moves everything at once: progress, momentum, journey, points and badges. **Ask FARO** opens the Mentor.

### 4. Community card

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One line with how many people are studying your course right now. It only appears if there is someone. Opens Community.

## 5. The four pillars

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**Focus** (your purpose) · **Advance** (the journey) · **Reward** (progress) · **Own** (the mentor). They are shortcuts, not new sections.

## 6. Your courses, momentum, rhythm and achievements

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Tappable summary cards. **Momentum** carries a word instead of just the number: *strong momentum* (65% or more), *regaining momentum* (40–64%), *your progress is safe* (under 40%). That last one never says you are doing badly.

## Safe harbour

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If you activated a planned pause from Recovery, Home is replaced by a single card saying your progress is exactly where you left it, with a button to continue whenever you want. No countdown, no reminders.

## 4. Journey

Answers **where am I going?** It is the course as a route, not as a list.

### Recalculation strip

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At the top, when your route drifted: *"Recalculating your route... Nothing was lost: the route below reorders itself around where you actually are."*

It is the GPS metaphor and it is literal: the route reorders, you are not scolded.

### The route

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Every activity is a stop, grouped by module. The state shows in the dot on the left:

| State        | How it looks         | What it means                                |
|--------------|----------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| Completed    | Green dot            | Submitted                                    |
| You are here | Mint dot with a halo | Your current position                        |
| Missed       | Hollow amber dot     | Overdue and still open — <b>never in red</b> |
| Upcoming     | Grey dot             | Not yet                                      |
| Locked       | Dimmed text          | Opens later                                  |

The stops that close a module are **checkpoints**: the dot becomes square and the label appears. They are the "you made it this far" moments.

Each stop carries its minutes and its date in plain language: *due today, due in 3 days, was due 2 days ago*. Never a count of how many you owe.

### The rest of this screen

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- **Header** with the percentage and, if you wrote it, your destination.
- **Next Best Step**, the same one as in Home — it is the same data, not a copy.
- **Your way back**, only if the route is recalculated: three short sessions.
- **One social line**, discreet: how many people worked on this module this week. Opens Community. It is one line on purpose — Journey is not a feed.

## 5. Recovery

The screen FARO exists for. It opens from the Home strip, or from SOS in Community.

**The rule that orders everything:** you are never shown everything you owe before being shown how you can finish.

### The order, and why it is that one

- 1. Checking your progress...** — one second. Skipped if your system has reduced motion.
- 2. Welcome back.** *"Your progress is still here. FARO recalculated your route."* Below, in small print: *"You were away 5 days."* It is a fact, not a reproach. It will never say "you lost 5 days".
- 3. Your current situation** — three numbers, not eighteen lines: days until the close, remaining work in hours, modules left.
- 4. Feasibility** — the honest answer to *can I still finish?* Four possible answers:

| Verdict                                           | When it appears                                | What it says                                 |
|---------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| <b>Yes, you can finish</b>                        | What is required fits comfortably in your time | Green, with the min/day needed               |
| <b>You can finish by picking up the pace</b>      | It needs a bit more than you sustain           | Amber, with both numbers                     |
| <b>Your original route is no longer realistic</b> | It does not reach                              | Dark green, not red, and offers alternatives |
| <b>FARO needs more information</b>                | No close date or no history                    | It does not guess                            |

The gauge compares what the course demands against what you sustain. The vertical line is 100%: crossing it means you are being asked for more than you said you have.

That third verdict is deliberate. FARO would rather tell you it does not reach and offer a shorter plan than cheer you on with something it cannot sustain.

- 5. What happened?** — optional, and it changes what FARO asks of you:

| If you choose...                | FARO...                                     |
|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| I have less time                | Shrinks your sessions to 10 minutes         |
| I'm overwhelmed                 | Hides the pile and leaves you a single step |
| I don't understand the material | Offers to take you to the Mentor            |
| I lost my routine               | Prepares a comeback mission                 |
| I need a break                  | Activates the safe harbour                  |

| If you choose...      | FARO...           |
|-----------------------|-------------------|
| I'm ready to continue | Resumes the route |

None changes dates or academic rules. The screen says so at the bottom, in those words.

**6. How much time do you have?** — 15, 30, 45, 60 min/day or **it varies every day**. That last one is the important one for an adult with an unpredictable schedule: it produces a flexible plan with a minimum goal, a recommended one and optional extra time.

**7. Route options** — three paces over the same work: **Comfortable, Balanced, Intensive**. Each says how many days it needs and how much slack it leaves, computed, not promised. At most one carries **Suggested for you**, and only when there is an objective reason: it is the closest to what you already sustain. None is called "the best".

**8. Your new route** — the first three days, with a button to see the rest. If something does not fit before the close, an amber notice says so: FARO does not hide the work that does not reach.

**9. Why did FARO change your route?** — collapsible. The five inputs of the calculation. The AI is not a black box.

**10. Today's one thing** — one action. If it is longer than your sessions, the text acknowledges it: *"Start it and pause when you need to — moving forward counts."*

**11. After completing it** — *"Done. You are back on route."* with your new momentum, and two exits: continue on the Journey or reconnect with the Community. Coming back to the course and coming back to people are two different returns.

## Recalculating

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Every time you change the time or the pace, **"Recalculating your route..."** appears and then **"Your route was updated"**. It is not decoration: the plan below is genuinely rebuilt.

## 6. FARO Mentor

The **FARO** tab. A chat, but not a generic chatbot: it only knows about your course and is built to guide you, not to do the work for you.

### How to use it

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It opens with a message that already knows your situation — different if you are back from an absence than if you are on track. Below every reply there are **follow-up chips**: tapping them sends that question without typing it. It is the fastest way to use it.

Type freely or use the chips. It understands questions about: what to do now, being behind, having little time, not understanding something, not feeling like it, and planning the week.

### The five styles

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At the top, as chips: **Direct, Encouraging, Detailed, Friendly, Challenge me**.

They change how it talks to you, never what it can do. "Challenge me" will not give you answers that "Encouraging" refuses; it just sounds different. The academic and safety rules are the same across all five.

### What it knows about you — exactly

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This is the complete list, and it is built in a single file of the code:

- The course name
- Your progress percentage
- Your next activity and how long it takes
- Your goal and your destination sentence
- The minutes you said you have
- Your momentum and your internal friction state
- The style and language you chose

**What it never receives:** your name, your email, your photo, your bio, your Canvas identifiers, your grades, your history of previous conversations. If a piece of data is not built in that file, the mentor never sees it. It is not a written policy: it is the only way it can receive data.

### What it will not do

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If you ask it to solve graded work, it refuses — and offers to break it into steps, explain the concept or review your reasoning. That refusal is the same across the five styles.

At the bottom of the screen is the note that says so without small print.

# 7. Community

Answers **who is with me?** It is a digital campus, not a social network. It is ordered by need, not by novelty.

## 1. Presence

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The dark green strip with a pulsing dot: how many people are studying your course now, how many are enrolled, how many are in rooms.

They are **counts, never people**. And since nobody appears by name, neither do you: the screen says so explicitly.

## 2. Your profile

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A button with your avatar. Opens Profile.

## 3. I'm stuck (SOS)

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The amber button. It is the piece that best explains FARO: **three kinds of stuck, three different systems**.

| If you say...                        | FARO takes you to... | Because...              |
|--------------------------------------|----------------------|-------------------------|
| I don't understand the topic         | <b>Mentor</b>        | You need an explanation |
| I don't know how to organise my time | <b>Recovery</b>      | You need a plan         |
| I want to talk to someone            | <b>Community</b>     | You need people         |

FARO does not answer every problem the same way, and Community is the answer to only one of the three.

## 4. Ask the community

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Four kinds: **Question, I'm stuck, Something I learned, Tip**. Optional title, required text. It is posted with the context of your course and current module, so whoever answers knows what you are talking about.

## 5. Study rooms

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Studying accompanied **without talking to anyone**. Each room shows a name, course, how many are inside, duration and mode: **quiet** or **pomodoro**.

When you join, the room takes the whole screen: a large clock, the avatars of those with you, and a line saying nobody sees whether you were productive — only that you were accompanied.

**Joining gives no points. Finishing does.** On completing the session: *"You studied alongside 5 people"* and +20 FARO points.

You can also **create a room** of 15, 25, 30, 45 or 60 minutes.

In the prototype the clock runs fast (one second per minute) so a full session can be shown. The screen says so.

## 6. Community mission

A collective goal for the week — for example, 500 activities between everyone. Your bar adds to everyone's. **Nobody competes**: when it is completed, everyone who took part receives recognition, regardless of how much each contributed.

## 7. The feed

Filters: All, Asking for help, Questions, Learnings.

**How it is ordered** — and this is the most important thing on the screen: **reactions do not count**. The order is decided by relevance to your course and module, whether someone is stuck and unanswered, and how recent it is. A post with forty reactions and one with zero rank the same if they are equally relevant to you.

And someone asking for help weighs **more** than someone celebrating an achievement. Landing on a front page full of other people's wins is the worst welcome for someone having a hard time.

**Reactions** are about learning, not popularity:

|                                                                                     | Means           |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|
|  | I like it       |
|  | You did it      |
|  | It helped me    |
|  | It motivates me |
|  | I'm with you    |

They are shown **separately**, never summed into a single number. "12 applauses" says what happened; "12 likes" would be a scoreboard.

Each kind of post offers the reactions that serve it: someone asking for help is offered *I'm with you*, not applause.

**Replies.** Tap the counter to open the thread. Every reply carries its origin: **Peer answer, from the instructor** or **FARO explanation**. A peer answer with forty helpful marks **is still** a peer answer, and the thread says so. There is also **Report** on every post.

## 8. Rewards and Progress

FARO gives points for **persisting**, not for clicking. Everything that awards points requires something real to have happened: an activity finished, a module closed, a return after disconnecting, an answer that helped someone.

### How points are earned

| Action                | Points | Exact rule                                                                                                        |
|-----------------------|--------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Complete an activity  | 10     | A study session recorded on a milestone.                                                                          |
| Close a module        | 50     | Paid once, when the last milestone of the module is completed.                                                    |
| Rhythm bonus          | +5     | Every 3 consecutive days with activity. What was earned is not lost when the streak breaks: it just stops adding. |
| Comeback bonus        | +25    | Paid once when you return after 3 or more days without activity (the friction threshold) and complete something.  |
| Answer marked helpful | +5     | Another student marked your answer as helpful in Community.                                                       |
| Finish a study room   | +20    | Joining the room gives no points. Finishing the full session does.                                                |

**Redemption:** 100 points = 1 reward unit. The Rewards screen shows the breakdown by origin — course, rhythm, comeback, community — so where every point came from can always be audited.

### Resilience achievements

There are five. None is earned by opening the app.

| Achievement                | Earned when                                                                           |
|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>The Comeback</b>        | You return after 3 or more days without activity and complete an activity.            |
| <b>Back on Track</b>       | You have at least 2 recorded sessions and your momentum is back to 65% or more.       |
| <b>Weathered the Storm</b> | You complete a session while having 2 or more overdue activities when you started it. |
| <b>Smart Session</b>       | You complete a session that fitted in the time you declared you had.                  |
| <b>Finisher</b>            | Your progress reaches 100%.                                                           |

While an achievement is not earned, FARO shows a **hint** of what it would take. Never a reproach.

## Community recognitions

| Recognition        | Earned when                                         |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| Community Builder  | You take part in the course space consistently.     |
| Knowledge Sharer   | You share resources or notes that others use.       |
| Helpful Peer       | Your answers accumulate helpful marks.              |
| Study Companion    | You complete study rooms alongside others.          |
| Community Comeback | You come back to the community after a period away. |

## Progress

The progress percentage is **not invented by FARO**: it comes from Canvas. It is activities with a recorded submission ÷ total course activities. An overdue date does not count as "done", and an activity that belongs to no module does not enter the count.

**Momentum** is different from progress: it measures current connection to learning, over a 14-day window, with a floor of 20. It never drops to zero. Progress once earned is never lost.

## 9. Profile

### How to get there

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Two ways, both valid:

1. **From Community** — tap your avatar or your name on the presence card, above the feed. It opens your public profile: what others see of you.
2. **From the bottom menu** — the Profile tab, next to Rewards.

### What is inside

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| Section                      | What it holds                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Who sees it                   |
|------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| <b>Name</b>                  | The name you choose to show. Empty until you set it.                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | Other students in the course. |
| <b>Photo</b>                 | A small square image, downsized in your own browser before being saved. The original is never uploaded.                                                                                                                                                                         | Other students in the course. |
| <b>Bio</b>                   | One line, optional.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | Other students in the course. |
| <b>Language</b>              | Spanish or English. Changes the whole interface and also the language the Mentor answers in.                                                                                                                                                                                    | Only you.                     |
| <b>Mentor style</b>          | Direct, encouraging, detailed, friendly or challenge me.                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | Only you.                     |
| <b>Your destination</b>      | The purpose you declared at the start, editable.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | Only you.                     |
| <b>Available time</b>        | The minutes per day you said you have. Change it when your life changes: it recalculates the whole route.                                                                                                                                                                       | Only you.                     |
| <b>Institutional account</b> | State of the link with Tecmilenio. <b>Labelled as simulated</b> in the prototype: there is no real SSO yet.                                                                                                                                                                     | Only you.                     |
| <b>Canvas</b>                | Technical panel: active mode ( <i>Simulated</i> or <i>Live</i> ), identified course, endpoints queried, refused scopes and a live request log. In <i>Live</i> mode it also says which backend the calls go through and whether activity is being derived from your submissions. | Only you.                     |

### Profile rules

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- **Nothing from the profile travels to the Mentor.** Not the name, not the photo, not the bio. The context the Mentor receives is built elsewhere and does not read this file.

- **Everything is stored locally** in the prototype. In production, the FARO backend is the source of truth so it can sync across devices.
- **Nothing is mandatory.** You can use the whole of FARO without a name or photo. You will appear with your initials.
- **Classmates never have a photo** in the prototype: only initials and a colour. Only your own avatar can carry an image.
- **There is no follower count, no level, no ranking.** The avatar colour is decoration, not status.

## 10. Rules FARO never breaks

These are not design preferences. They are limits written in the code, and any new feature has to respect them.

- 1. There is no Game Over.** No system state kicks you out of the course, locks content for inactivity or erases progress. The worst possible scenario is *"recalculating your route"*.
- 2. Progress is not lost.** Not for missing a day, not for missing three weeks. Breaking a streak stops *adding*; it never *subtracts*.
- 3. We never show you a risk score.** Internally the system computes friction states to decide how to help you. You will never see "dropout risk: 87%". You will see "your route needs attention" and a concrete action.
- 4. When you come back, we do not greet you with the debt.** Never "you have 14 overdue activities". First "welcome back, your progress is still here", then a route.
- 5. FARO does not do your graded work.** The Mentor explains, gives hints, organises and accompanies. If you ask it to solve an exam or write your submission, it refuses and offers help so you can do it yourself.
- 6. The Mentor sees only eleven fields.** Course, progress, next activity, estimated time, your declared goal, your destination in your words, available time, momentum, friction state, style and language. It does not see your name, your email, your grades, your photo or your full history.
- 7. FARO does not write to Canvas.** The permission to submit grades exists in the LTI standard and we explicitly refuse it. Canvas is the academic source of truth; FARO only reads.
- 8. FARO does not change dates or academic rules.** It can reorganise *your personal* study plan. The course deadlines are set by the institution and only it can move them.
- 9. If you are not going to make it, we tell you.** The verdict "not realistic" exists on purpose. FARO would rather offer you the best possible scenario and a conversation with your instructor than promise something it cannot sustain.
- 10. There are no leaderboards.** Community shows aggregate presence ("23 studying now"), never "Andrea has been at it for 37 minutes". The feed orders by usefulness for learning, not by reactions: a request for help weighs more than an achievement.
- 11. No badge spam.** Five resilience achievements and five community recognitions. All require having persisted through something. None is earned by clicking.
- 12. FARO must not become another burden.** If a feature makes the product heavier, slower, more confusing or more invasive without improving persistence, it is not implemented.

**Hard to quit. Easy to return. No Game Over. Recalculate your route.**